SPECIAL REPORT · COMMODITIES & CORRIDORS

Nigeria's export map is being *rewritten*

How a 159% non-oil surge, a 606% cocoa rally, and a new deep-sea port are reshaping Africa's largest economy in 2024–2025.

NORHAVEN INTELLIGENCE · APRIL 2026

VOLUME I · EXPORT ECONOMIES

THE NUMBERS THAT DEFINE THE YEAR

+159%
YoY growth in non-oil exports, Q4 2024

+606%
Cocoa export surge, Q4 2024 vs Q4 2023

40.6%
Lekki Deep Sea Port's share of national cargo

$23–35B
Estimated annual African gold flows to the UAE

The centerpiece of Nigeria's economic 2024: cocoa exports leapt 606% to ₦1.2 trillion, port export-laden containers spiked eleven-fold, and Lekki Deep Sea Port overtook Apapa. Yet oil still pays $11.5 of every $13.5 billion in foreign earnings, ginger production collapsed under blight, and billions in gold still move informally to Dubai. What follows maps the commodities, the producing states behind them, and the corridors moving them to world markets.

§ EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The three shifts reshaping *Nigeria's export economy*

Nigeria's export economy underwent its most dramatic structural shift in a generation, driven by currency depreciation, new port capacity, global commodity price spikes, and a decisive policy pivot toward diversification.

Three forces converged in 2024–2025 to rewrite Nigeria's export playbook. First, non-oil exports surged 159% year-on-year in the fourth quarter of 2024 to reach ₦2.84 trillion, driven by record global cocoa prices, naira depreciation, and new agricultural volume from the northern savanna. Second, the commissioning of Lekki Deep Sea Port fundamentally altered Nigeria's maritime geography. By 2025 the new port handled 40.6% of national cargo throughput, overtaking the century-old Apapa complex and, for the first time in a decade, enabling direct transshipment to neighbouring West African states. Third, the Tinubu administration's solid minerals pivot, the lifting of the five-year Zamfara mining ban, and new bilateral engagement with the UAE over gold flows signalled that formalisation of the artisanal sector is now treated as a multi-billion-dollar policy target rather than a law-enforcement afterthought.

> *"Nigeria is genuinely diversifying for the first time since oil's 1970s takeoff. But the mechanism is as much currency-driven as structural."*
>
> REPORT FINDING · §7 CONCLUSIONS

01 OIL STILL PAYS THE BILLS

Mineral fuels deliver *85%* of export value. The share is loosening

Crude production recovered to 1.6 million barrels per day in early 2024, and the new Dangote refinery is reshaping Nigeria from gasoline importer to potential regional exporter.

Mineral fuels generated $11.5 billion of Nigeria's $13.5 billion in Q1 2025 exports, anchored by Bonny Light and Forcados crude from the Niger Delta. The destination mix has diversified meaningfully: the Netherlands bought $1.06 billion (9.2%) as a refined-products re-export hub, France $936 million (8.1%), Spain $899 million (7.8%), and the United States $791 million (6.9%). Crude production recovered to roughly 1.6 million barrels per day in early 2024, helped by the commissioning of the 650,000 bpd Dangote refinery, which is reshaping Nigeria from a gasoline importer into a potential regional exporter.

The quiet petrochemical giant

The fertiliser story is the quiet giant beside oil. **Urea exports alone hit ₦856 billion (US$561.7 million) in Q1 2025**, nearly quadrupling Q1 2024's ₦240.6 billion, with Nigeria now supplying Brazil, India, and the United States. Indorama's Eleme complex in Rivers State and Dangote Fertilizer's Lekki plant together are pushing national capacity past 5 million metric tons annually, positioning Nigeria as West Africa's petrochemical hub.

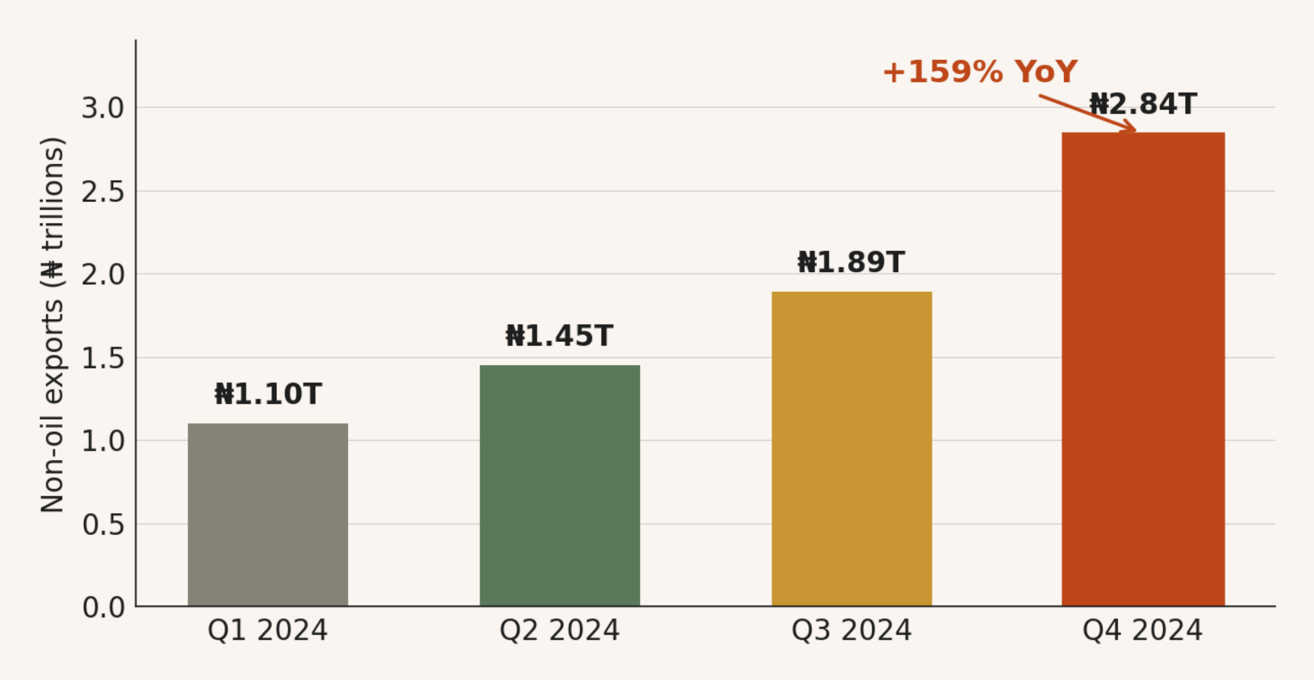

Figure 1 · Non-oil exports surged through 2024. Q4 2024 alone reached ₦2.84 trillion (a 159% year-on-year increase), anchored by cocoa, sesame, urea, and cashew. Source: NBS Foreign Trade Statistics.

Europe now absorbs a combined 25% of mineral fuels exports, while the US's 6.9% share marks a structural decline from its pre-shale dominance.

02 COCOA · SOUTHWEST BELT

Cocoa's *sevenfold rally* is remaking the southwest

Ondo, Cross River, Edo, Osun, and Ekiti have become Nigeria's agricultural poster child, but the 300,000 smallholder farmers behind the boom now face a hard EU compliance deadline.

Earnings between June 2024 and June 2025 totalled ₦3.6 trillion, a sevenfold leap, with Q1 2025 raw-bean exports alone worth ₦1.32 trillion. The Netherlands bought $809 million in 2024 (roughly 46% of cocoa export value) as the processing gateway to Europe; Belgium, Germany, Malaysia, and the United States fill out the top five destinations. Nigeria's 2024/25 crop is estimated at 344,000 tonnes, making it the world's fourth-largest producer behind Côte d'Ivoire (2.23M MT), Ghana, and Ecuador.

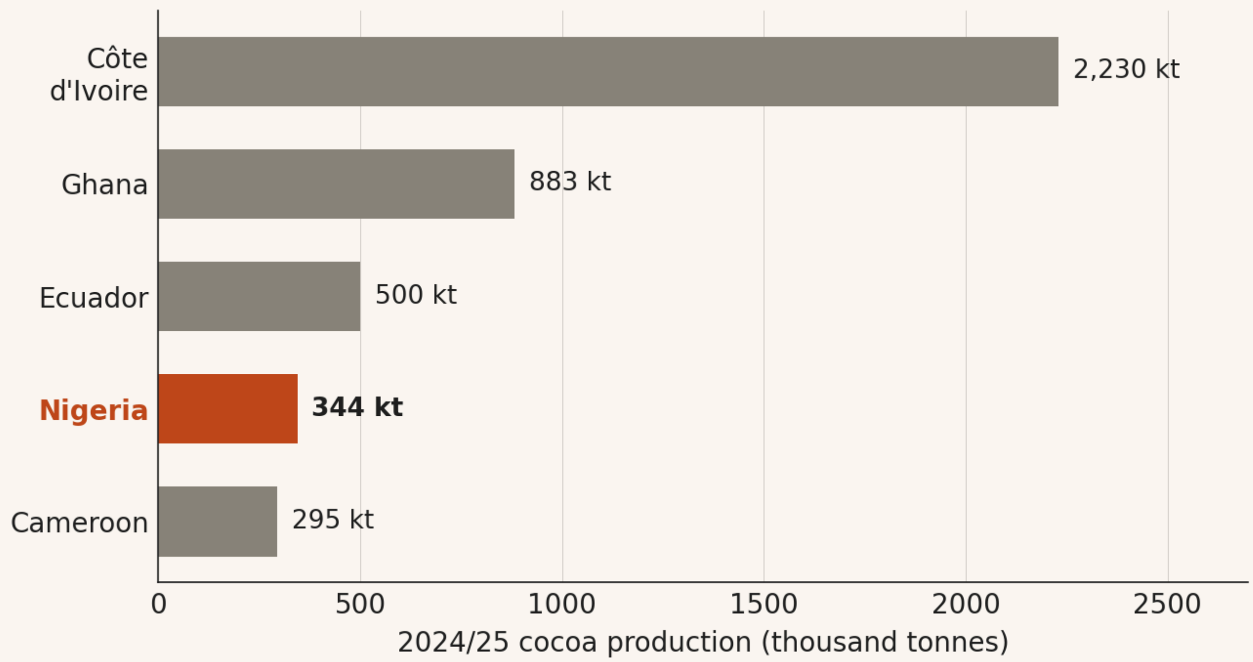

Figure 2 · Nigeria is fourth globally, but a distant fourth. Production at 344,000 tonnes is roughly one-seventh of Côte d'Ivoire's output. Source: ICCO and Cocoa Association of Nigeria, 2024/25 season estimates.

> *A realistic ceiling is 370,000 tonnes. The federal 500,000-tonne target is widely seen as aspirational.*
>
> AKIN LAOYE · CEO, FTN COCOA PROCESSORS

The Cocoa Association of Nigeria projects an **11% decline to 305,000 tonnes in 2025/26** due to aging trees and weather. The binding constraint is EUDR compliance: from 2026, cocoa entering the EU must be proven deforestation-free, requiring farm-level geolocation for Nigeria's roughly **300,000 smallholder farmers** who produce 80% of output.

Where the beans go

The concentration of buyers is striking. Johnvents (UK-backed), Sunbeth, and WACOT are leading traceability and certification drives, but rural replanting windows are tight, and the 2026 EUDR cut-off will expose any farm without GPS-verified deforestation-free status to an effective European market ban.

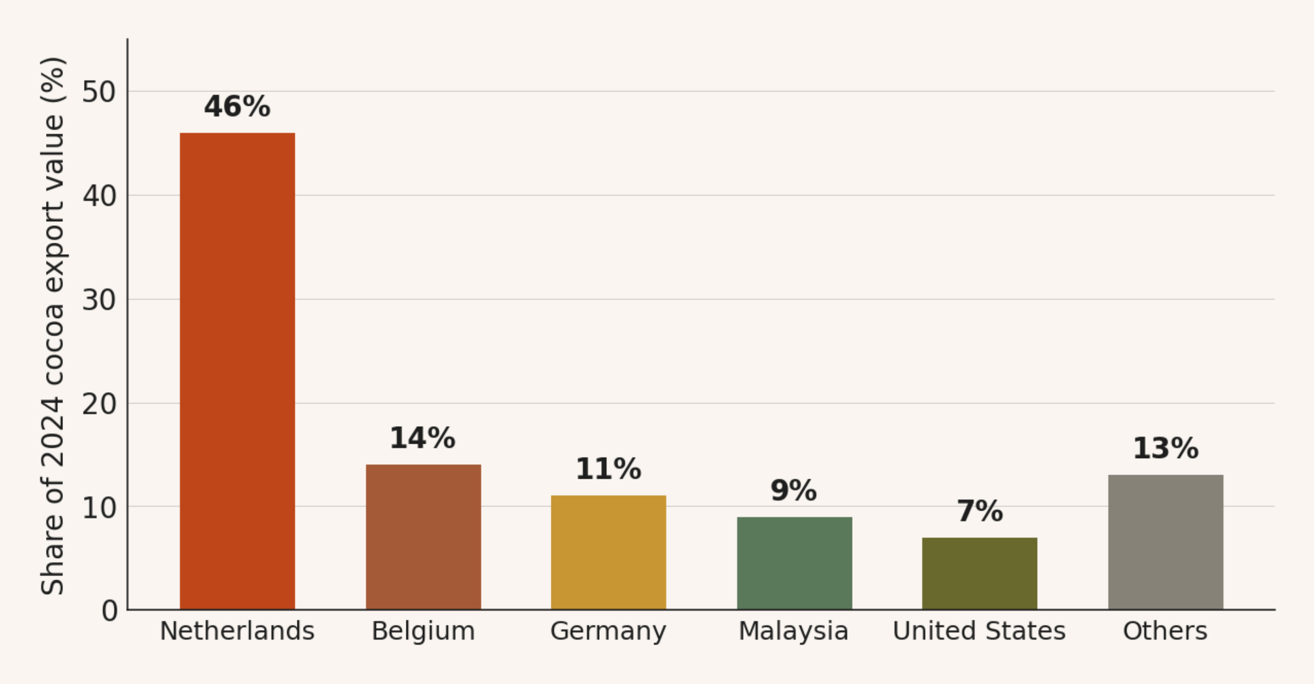

Figure 3 · The Netherlands absorbs nearly half of all Nigerian cocoa value. Dutch processors act as the European gateway, re-exporting finished and semi-finished products across the EU. Source: NBS 2024 Q4 trade statistics.

Three risks, one window

Three structural risks hang over the current rally. **First**, the surge is price-driven. Global cocoa hit historic highs in late 2024, and Nigerian volume remains a fraction of Ivorian output. If prices normalise, naira-denominated export value will fall even if volume holds. **Second**, the December 2025 EUDR enforcement creates a binary outcome: compliant farms retain EU access, non-compliant farms lose 46% of their buyer base overnight. **Third**, tree age. Most Nigerian cocoa trees are past their peak productive years, and replanting is a 4–7 year capital-intensive proposition that smallholders cannot finance without off-taker support.

THE ONDO PREMIUM

Ondo State alone produced roughly 77,000–95,000 tonnes in 2024, the single largest subnational cocoa output in West Africa outside Côte d'Ivoire. The Akure-Ikare corridor is the operational spine; fermentation racks cluster around Owena, Idanre, and Ile-Oluji.

Both Ondo and Cross River's Ikom Valley funnel south to Lagos Apapa and, increasingly, to Lekki for containerised export.

The operational takeaway for exporters: **the window for EUDR-compliant origin contracts is closing fast**. Farms that cannot produce geolocation data by Q4 2025 will be squeezed into lower-tier markets (Malaysia, UAE, regional) at discounts of 15–25% to EU prices. First-mover aggregators with digital traceability platforms stand to capture structural margin in the compliance transition.

03 SESAME · HIBISCUS · GINGER

Sesame, hibiscus, and ginger: a *divergent* triad

The northern savanna runs a parallel export economy built on three commodities with sharply different trajectories. Two hit record prices. One collapsed under blight.

Sesame seed is Nigeria's biggest non-cocoa agricultural earner. The country produced roughly 510,000 tonnes in 2022 and ranks as the world's largest sesame exporter by value in 2024, with prices rising 42% to $2,290 per tonne. The buying centres (Malam-Madori in Jigawa, Doma in Nasarawa, Potiskum in Yobe, and the vast Dawanau grain market in Kano) funnel crop from 26 states toward China, Japan, Turkey, Vietnam, and South Korea. Only three functional processing plants nationwide handle meaningful value addition.

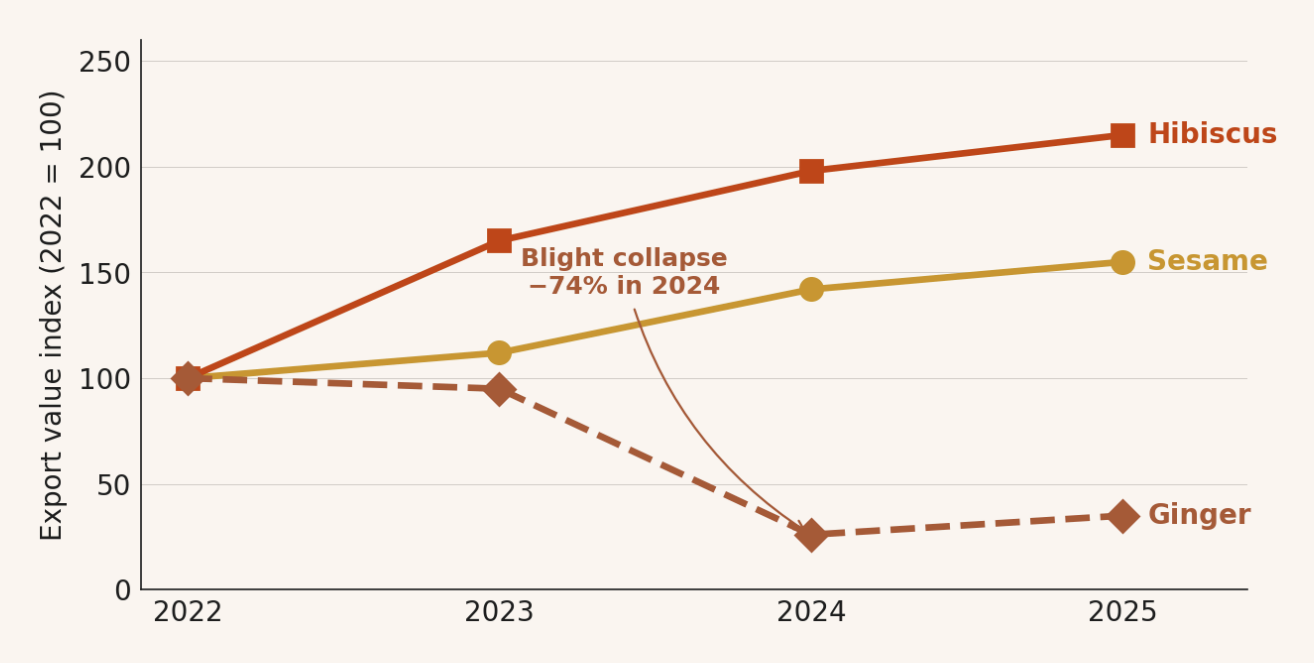

Figure 4 · Three commodities, three trajectories. Hibiscus rebounded on Mexico's reopened market, sesame rode a 42% price rally, and ginger collapsed under fungal blight, a 74% export-value decline in the first nine months of 2024. Index 2022 = 100.

Hibiscus: Mexico reopens the tap

Hibiscus roared back after Mexico reopened its market in April 2021 following a four-year ban over pest contamination. **Mexico now absorbs roughly 85% of Nigeria's hibiscus exports**, used in the Agua de Jamaica beverage, with Jigawa, Katsina, Kano, Bauchi, Kebbi, and Sokoto supplying the bulk. Farmgate prices jumped from ₦800,000–₦1 million per tonne pre-ban to ₦1.7–2 million by 2023, pulling farmers out of maize and sorghum. AgroEknor alone targets 2,400 tonnes yearly from the Kano-Jigawa clusters.

Ginger tells the opposite story

Before 2023, Nigeria was the world's second-largest ginger producer at **750,000–800,000 tonnes annually**, with Kaduna State contributing over 60%, primarily from Kachia, Kagarko, Zango-Kataf, Jaba, Jema'a, Kaura, and Sanga LGAs. A fungal blight outbreak wiped out over 2,500 hectares and 85–95% of yields, costing farmers roughly ₦12 billion. NBS data show ginger export revenue collapsed 74% to ₦6.28 billion in the first nine months of 2024.

> *Ethiopia, China, and India have captured lost market share in Europe and the Middle East, markets that took a decade to build and may not fully return.*
>
> EXPORT PROMOTION COUNCIL BRIEFING · 2024

The federal Ginger Blight Epidemic Control Taskforce (GBECT) and the ₦1.6 billion GRATE initiative reached 5,000 farmers, and 2025 harvests show about 60% of Kachia farms recovering, but seed scarcity still caps output. For at least two crop cycles, Nigeria is effectively off the global ginger map, and rebuilding offtake relationships will require verified blight-free certification and aggressive pricing against East African suppliers.

The structural gap: processing

Across all three commodities, the binding constraint is processing capacity. Sesame hulling, hibiscus grading, and ginger washing-and-splitting lines are overwhelmingly concentrated in Lagos and Kano. Producers in Jigawa, Yobe, Katsina, and Taraba ship raw product south, meaning the bulk of export value accrues to Lagos-based aggregators rather than the northern farmgate. Any serious upgrade requires **processing-plant deployment within 200 km of the farmgate**, which means solving power, water, and security simultaneously.

WHERE THE VALUE LEAKS

Sesame: 97% of volume ships as raw seed; processing margin captured in China and Turkey.

Hibiscus: solar-drying quality issues force price discounts; tea-bag and extract production all offshore.

Ginger: powder, oleoresin and oil markets inaccessible without blight-free certification and processing capacity.

04 GOLD · LITHIUM · CRITICAL MINERALS

Gold, lithium, and the *reshaping* of solid minerals

Nigeria's formal gold sector runs through a single asset. The informal sector dwarfs it by an order of magnitude. Closing that gap is now the country's biggest single policy target.

Nigeria's formal gold sector runs through one asset: Thor Explorations' Segilola mine in Osun State, roughly 120 km northeast of Lagos. It produced 85,057 ounces in 2024 and 91,910 ounces in 2025 at realised prices above $2,497 per ounce in Q4 2024. FY2026 guidance is 75,000–85,000 oz at all-in sustaining costs of $1,000–1,200/oz, with underground drilling aiming to extend the mine beyond its current 2028 plan.

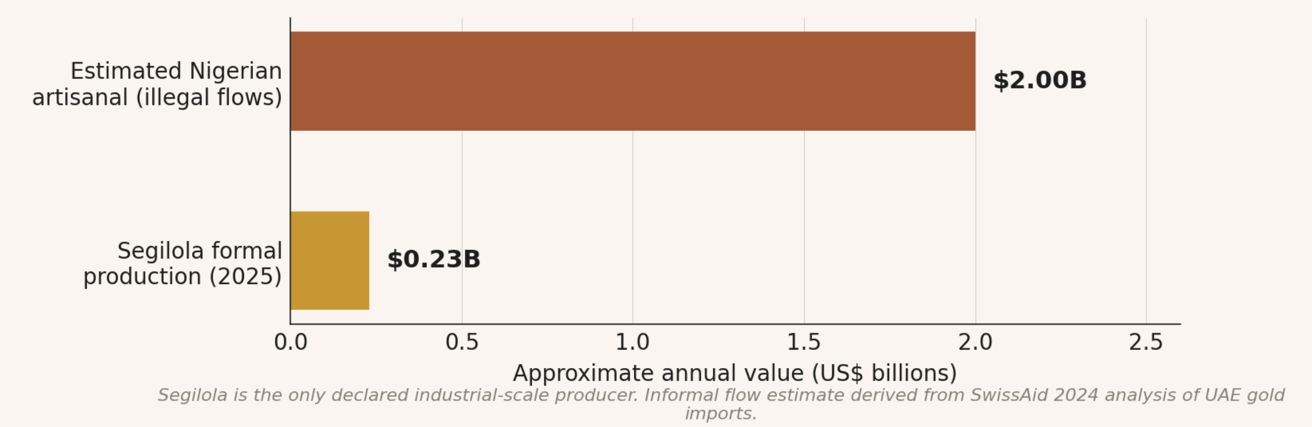

Figure 5 · The gold gap is nearly an order of magnitude. Segilola's declared output is roughly $230 million annually; SwissAid 2024 analysis of UAE gold imports implies Nigerian artisanal flows approaching $2 billion.

> *A large portion of Nigerian gold is ending up in the UAE unlawfully.*
>
> DELE ALAKE · MINISTER OF SOLID MINERALS, OCTOBER 2024

Zamfara reopens, rare earths surge

In December 2024 the Tinubu administration **lifted the five-year mining ban on Zamfara State**, where gold, lithium, and copper belts had been frozen since 2019 over banditry, following security improvements. The state's artisanal gold belt also remains the site of one of the worst lead-poisoning epidemics in modern history, because local ore contains lead.

The critical-minerals story runs parallel. Ebonyi's Abakaliki-Enyigba-Ameka axis produces lead and zinc, largely through artisanal operations, with output moving to Chinese smelters. The Jos Plateau, historically the world's largest columbite producer, now runs on artisanal operations, with Nigeria's **rare-earth oxide production jumping roughly 80% to 13,000 tonnes in 2024**, placing it among the world's top five REE producers via monazite from Plateau's Kanam area and placer sands in Cross River.

05 PORTS & MARITIME

Ports are finally *catching up* with the cargo

Nigeria's export surge ran headlong into port infrastructure for years. A single new deep-sea port commissioned in April 2023 changed the geometry of West African trade.

The Lagos Port Complex at Apapa still handled about ₦74.78 trillion in Q1–Q3 2025 combined trade, operated under five concessions awarded in 2006: APM Terminals (containers), ENL Consortium (break bulk), Apapa Bulk Terminal Limited (dry bulk), Greenview Development, and Lilypond ICT. Tin Can Island Port adds Josepdam, TICT, Port & Cargo, and Five Star Logistics.

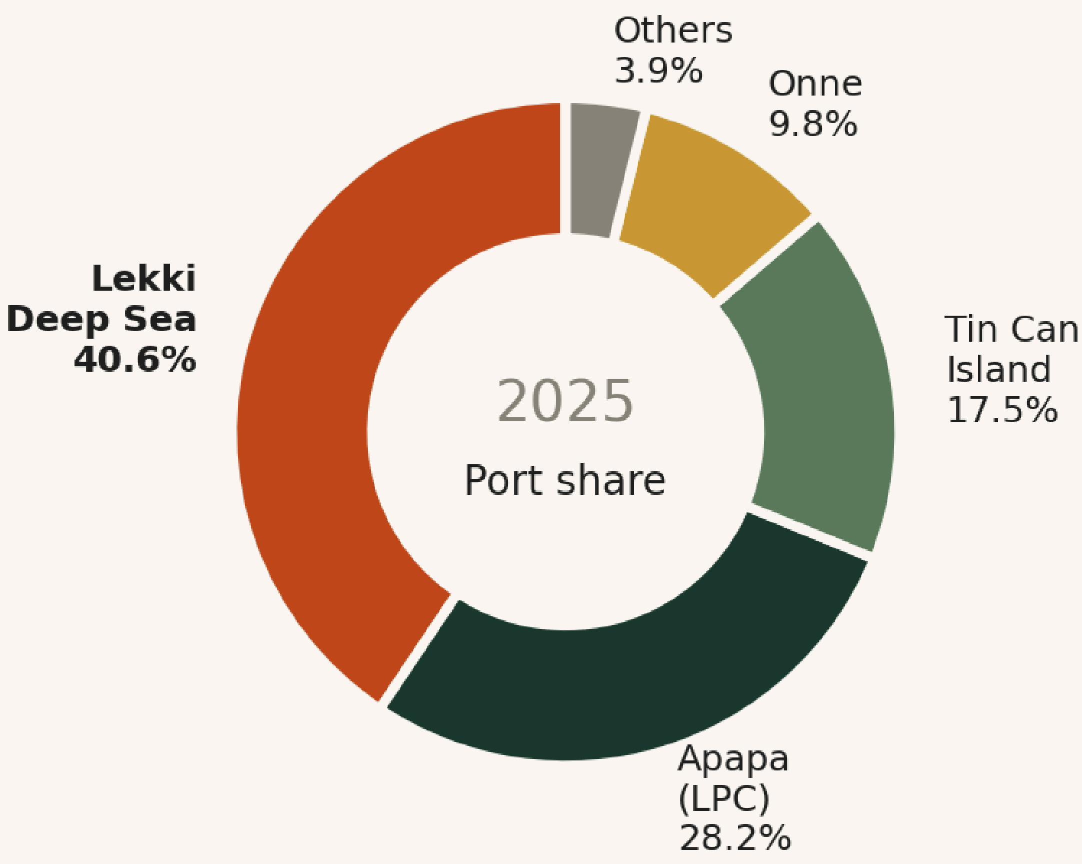

Figure 6 · Lekki Deep Sea Port now handles 40.6% of national cargo throughput. In just over two years since commissioning in April 2023, Lekki has overtaken the century-old Apapa complex on volume. Source: Nigerian Ports Authority 2025 statistics.

The structural shock: Lekki

The structural shock is Lekki Deep Sea Port, commissioned in April 2023 with a 16.5-metre draft and the first ship-to-shore super-post-Panamax cranes in Nigeria. By 2025 Lekki handled 40.6% of Nigeria's total cargo throughput, the single largest share of any port, with Lekki Freeport Terminal moving **503,443 TEUs in 2025 (up from 284,297 in 2024)**, reaching about 50% of installed capacity.

The transshipment pivot

Critically, Lekki has begun **regional transshipment to Togo, Benin, Ghana, and Abidjan**, reversing the decade-long pattern in which Nigeria-bound cargo was routed through Lomé or Tema. Q3 2025 NPA data capture the broader shift: total containers rose 18.9% to 546,931 TEUs, vessel calls climbed 8.4% to 1,074, and export-laden containers surged from 5,812 to 69,039 TEUs, an 11-fold leap reflecting cocoa, sesame, urea, and cashew volumes moving out rather than in.

> *Export-laden containers surged 1,085% in a single quarter, a reversal of Nigeria's decade-long status as a cargo importer.*
>
> NPA Q3 2025 CONTAINER STATISTICS

Onne Port in Rivers State (₦6.76 trillion in Q1–Q3 2025 trade) anchors oil-services logistics under Intels Nigeria Limited's contested concessions, while Port Harcourt, Warri, and Calabar handle smaller specialised volumes. Rail connection from Apapa's APM terminal inland and the planned Lekki rail link remain the critical missing piece for evacuating northern sesame, hibiscus, and cocoa to tidewater without road bottlenecks.

THE FOUR GATEWAYS AT A GLANCE

Lekki Deep Sea Port: 16.5m draft, 40.6% national share, super-post-Panamax cranes, transshipment-enabled.

Apapa (Lagos Port Complex): 28.2% share, five terminal concessions, APM + ENL anchor.

Tin Can Island: 17.5% share, ten-berth complex, TICT and Josepdam operate.

Onne: 9.8% share, oil-services and FTZ, Intels concession anchor.

The inland connection is still the weak link

For all the Lekki headlines, the critical last mile remains inland. Northern cargo (sesame from Jigawa, hibiscus from Kano, ginger from Kaduna) still moves overwhelmingly by road along the A2 and A3 corridors, exposed to bandit activity and checkpoint extortion estimated at ~₦100,000 per trip. The June 2024 reopening of the Lagos–Kano narrow-gauge freight line and the November 2024 Lagos–Ibadan standard-gauge freight authorisation partially close this gap. **The next inflection point will be the Lekki rail spur** (still on the drawing board), which would allow direct container evacuation from the deep-sea port without the Apapa road gridlock that has defined Nigerian logistics for a generation.

06 WHAT THE NEW EXPORT MAP TELLS US

Three conclusions for 2026 and beyond

Three conclusions emerge from the 2024–2025 shift. They are not mutually exclusive, but each has different implications for operators, policymakers, and investors depending on their position in the chain.

01 Nigeria is genuinely diversifying, but the mechanism is fragile

The country is genuinely diversifying for the first time since oil's 1970s takeoff, but the mechanism is as much currency-driven as structural. Naira depreciation inflated foreign earnings in local terms, and global cocoa and gold price spikes did the heavy lifting. Should commodity prices normalise, the volume story alone is softer: Nigeria produces only 344,000 tonnes of cocoa versus Côte d'Ivoire's 2.2 million. The structural gains (Lekki port, refinery commissioning, Zamfara reopening) are real but slower to mature than the headline trade numbers suggest.

02 Geography now determines policy leverage

The southwest cocoa belt, the northern oilseed-hibiscus belt, Osun's single gold mine, Kaduna's fragile ginger cluster, and the Lagos port triangle do not share institutional priorities. EUDR compliance matters in Ondo, security matters in Zamfara, seed systems matter in Kachia, and rail infrastructure matters in Lagos. The federal diversification narrative masks these divergent bottlenecks, and the corridors that get state-level buy-in will outperform corridors that only have federal attention.

03 The smuggling gap is now the biggest single policy target

Roughly $23–35 billion of African gold flows to Dubai annually outside formal channels, and Nigeria is a material contributor; Togo's 52 tonnes of UAE gold imports in 2024, despite negligible domestic mining, likely include smuggled Nigerian artisanal output. If the Tinubu administration's UAE engagement and Zamfara regulation translate into even partial formalisation, declared mineral exports could double within two years without a single additional ounce being mined. That is a bigger prize than another cocoa rally, and one where Nigeria's commodity geography finally intersects with governance, not just weather.

Norhaven Intelligence · Volume I · Export Economies

This report synthesises data from the Nigerian Bureau of Statistics, Nigerian Ports Authority, Thor Explorations Ltd. disclosures, SwissAid 2024 gold-flow analysis, Cocoa Association of Nigeria, NBS foreign trade reports Q1–Q3 2025, and published commentary from Nigerian news outlets including BusinessDay, Nairametrics, Punch, Premium Times, and Channels Television.

Figures reflect publicly available data as of April 2026. Where estimates are used (particularly for informal gold flows), methodology and source are noted in the relevant figure captions. Forward-looking statements are based on the referenced sources and should not be construed as investment advice.